

REEL LOVE Actor Bhavin Rabari in a still from Pan Nalin's *Chhelo Show* (Last Film Show)

"[With *Chhelo Show*], I wanted to be a child again. I wanted to recollect how I was hypnotised by the light on the screen,"," says Pan Nalin

For a few months in the mid-70s, filmgoers in Gujarat's Amreli district began to notice that the movies being screened in their theatres were incomplete. The police began investigating and it was discovered that nine-year-old Pan Nalin (born Nalin Kumar Pandya) and his friends were stealing a few reels out of the aluminium trunks they were transported in. "This was around the time when I had just fallen in love with movies. I used to help my father sell tea at Khijadiya station [in Amreli] and we realised that the trunks kept in the parcel room had Amitabh Bachchan films. We'd pull out a reel, unspool it and look at every frame," the director remembers with a laugh. Nalin ended up in a local juvenile home for about four days and promised never to steal again.

It's this love for the movies that is reflected in Nalin's Gujarati film *Chhelo Show* (Last Film Show), which has been selected as India's official entry to the 2023 Academy Awards. "The world was going through a huge transformation with the arrival of streaming and the corporatisation of entertainment. Filmmaking was being taught in schools and we were producing filmmakers like engineers and astronauts. I just wanted to be a child again, to try and recollect how I was hypnotised and mesmerised by the light on the screen." Shot just before the country went into lockdown in 2020, *Chhelo Show* premiered in the Spotlight section of the 20th Tribeca Festival.

Much like Samay (Bhavin Rabari) in the film, young Nalin would often be thrown out of the local cinema hall in Khijadiya for watching films without a ticket. The theatre manager finally gave him a job. "There were a lot of pigeons who would sit in the rafters and get startled every time there was a loud noise. My job was to catch them and set them loose outside." It was here that Nalin met Mohammedbhai, the theatre's projectionist. "He would let me watch films from the projection room and I would share my school tiffin with him."

This friendship withstood time even as Nalin left Khijadiya, first to study Fine Arts in Baroda and then to make films like *Valley of Flowers* (2006) and *Angry Indian Goddesses* (2015). It was a meeting with Mohammedbhai about a decade ago that led to *Chhelo Show*. "I hadn't met him in a long time and that's when I realised that he had lost his job because digital projection systems had come in. He was a third-generation projectionist who had started working with his father at the age of 12. And now, he was selling vegetables."

Chhelo Show is perhaps Nalin's most special film yet, and not just because it's autobiographical. "There's a lot of my family in the film. All the food that's featured in the film was cooked by my brother using our mother's recipes. The tiffin-boxes used in the film are the same ones that my mother would pack our food